

Semi Pelagianism Denial

doc-semi-pelagianism-denial

Soteriology · Denied Errors · doctrine · divided_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness inferred
variants stable

Statement under examination

The sinner does not take the first step toward God by natural ability with grace then assisting; rather, the prior gracious work of God enables any movement of the will toward Him.

In plain language

The Greek of these verses keeps putting God's action before the person's first move toward him. In John 6:44 and 6:65 the words say no one 'is able' (dynatai) to come 'unless' (ean me) the Father first 'draws' (helkyo), or 'has given', a completed-with-standing-result form marking a settled earlier gift. The same verb for 'draw' (helkyo) is used elsewhere for hauling a net and dragging people to court, so it is a real pull, not just an offer. John 15:16 flips the order plainly, 'you did not choose me but I chose you' (forms of 'to choose', eklegomai). 1 John 4:19 says we love because he 'first' (protos) loved us. In Acts 16:14 the Lord 'opened' (dianoigo) Lydia's heart so that she paid attention, the opening coming before the attending. Romans 9:16 says it does not depend on the 'one who wills' (tou thelontos) but on the God who shows 'mercy' (eleontos), and Philippians 2:13 says God is the one 'working' (energon) in believers even the 'willing' (to thelein) itself. Taken together these priority words say the first step is God's, which is exactly the point in question, because semi-Pelagianism is the claim that the person makes the first move by natural ability and grace only helps afterward. The words push against that. There is still a narrower and separate question the vocabulary does not settle. Once grace has gone first, does that prior work by itself fully produce the willing, or does it enable a will that then genuinely and freely consents. Careful readers divide here, and both sides agree the divine act comes first. They differ only on how complete that prior work is. Because the verbs clearly make the initiating act God's, the evidence affirms that grace must begin the movement, while the completeness of that prior work stays open, so confidence is medium rather than high.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0025	ἀγαπῶμεν	agapaō	to love	
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	
G1223	διὰ	dia	through/because of	
G1272	διανοίγω	dianoigo	to open up	9
G1325	δίδωμι	didomi	to give	428
G1410	δύναμαι	dynamai	be able	211
G1435	δῶρον	doron	gift	19
G1473	ἐγὼ	egō	I/we	
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G1586	ἐκλέγομαι	eklegomai	to select	22

G1653	ἐλεέω	eleeo	to have mercy	32
G1670	ἐλκύω	helkyo	to draw/persuade	8
G1754	ἐνεργέω	energeo	be active	21
G2041	ἔργων	ergon	work	
G2064	ἐλθεῖν	erchomai	to come/go	
G2107	εὐδοκία	eudokia	goodwill	9
G2309	θέλω	thelo	to will/desire	214
G2316	θεοῦ	theos	God	
G2443	ἵνα	hina	in order that/to	
G2588	καρδίαν	kardia	heart	
G2744	καυχῆσθαι	kauchaomai	to boast	
G2962	κύριος	kurios	lord	
G3756	οὐ	ou	no	
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G4337	προσέχειν	prosechō	to watch out	
G4771	ὁμεῖς	su	you	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

On the narrow question of who starts the movement toward God, the cited Greek consistently puts the divine act before the human movement. John 6:44 and 6:65 join the negated verb 'is able' (dynatai, an ongoing simple statement of fact) to the 'unless' condition (ean me), so coming is impossible unless the Father first 'draws' (helkyse, a completed past action in the subjunctive mood, that is, a hypothetical or conditional completed pull) or 'has given' (dedomenon, a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive voice). Romans 9:16 negates 'of the one willing' (ou tou thelontos) with the strong 'but' (alla) relocating the ground to 'of the God who shows mercy' (tou eleontos theou), and Philippians 2:13 names God as 'working' (energon, the ongoing present participle) even the 'willing' itself (to thelein, the act of willing). John 15:16 reverses the order, 'you did not choose me but I chose you' (ouch hymeis exelexasthe all ego exelexamen), and 1 John 4:19 marks God as 'first' (protos). Acts 16:14 has the Lord 'opened' (dienoixen) the heart so as 'to attend' (prosechein), the opening preceding the attending. These priority markers foreclose the semi-Pelagian claim (the teaching that the unaided human takes the first step toward God and grace only helps afterward) that the human takes the unaided first step. The distinct and narrower cooperation question, whether the prior work fully effects the willing or enables a will that still freely consents, is not ranked by the vocabulary, hence medium confidence.

Scripture

John.6.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1410 δύναται, G1670 ἐλκύση, G2064 ἐλθεῖν, G3962 πατήρ

Force. The negated verb 'is able' (dynatai, an ongoing simple statement of fact) joined to the condition 'unless' (ean me, an 'if-then' clause in negative form) makes coming impossible apart from a prior act of the Father. That act is 'should draw' (helkyse, a completed past action in the active subjunctive mood, that is, a conditional completed pull) from the verb 'to draw' (helkyo, meaning draw or drag). Across its eight occurrences in the Bible the verb 'to draw' (helkyo) names a forceful effective drawing: dragging Paul and Silas to the marketplace in Acts 16:19, dragging from the temple in Acts 21:30, drawing a sword in John 18:10, hauling the net in John 21:6 and 21:11. So the verb here describes an initiating divine pull, not a mere offer, and the coming follows it rather than precedes it.

John.6.65 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1410 δύναται, G1325 δεδομένον, G1537 ἐκ, G3962 πατρός

Force. The same negated 'is able' (dynatai, an ongoing simple statement of fact) plus 'unless' (ean me, an 'if-then' clause in negative form) construction grounds the ability to come in the participle 'it has been given' (dedomenon, a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive voice), 'from the Father' (ek tou patros). This verse uses the verb 'to give' (didomi) rather than 'to draw' (helkyo), and the completed-with-standing-result tense marks a settled prior gift as the standing precondition of the human approach, again placing the divine act first.

Rom.9.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2309 θέλοντος, G1653 ἐλεῶντος, G3756 οὐ, G2316 θεοῦ

Force. The clause negates 'of the one willing' (ou tou thelontos) and 'nor of the one running' (oude tou trechontos), then with the strong 'but' (alla) locates the determining ground in 'of the God who shows mercy' (tou eleontos theou). Human willing, the very faculty the semi-Pelagian (the view that the unaided human takes the first step) first step would exercise, is expressly displaced as the operative cause and the merciful God is named instead.

Phil.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G1754 ἐνεργῶν, G2309 θέλειν, G2107 εὐδοκίας

Force. The causal 'for' (gar) grounds the preceding exhortation in God who is 'working' (energon, the ongoing present active participle of the verb 'to work in' (energeo)), working in believers both 'to will' (to thelein, the act of willing) and 'to work' (to energein, the act of working), for his 'good pleasure' (eudokia). Including the infinitive 'to will' (to thelein) within God's operation places the gracious work prior to and beneath the act of the will itself, which is the precise point the proposition asserts.

John.15.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1586 ἐξελέσασθε, G1586 ἐξελεξάμην, G1473 ἐγώ, G4771 ὑμεῖς

Force. The verse reverses the order of initiative directly: 'you did not choose me' (ouch hymeis me exelexasthe), 'but I chose you' (all ego exelexamen hymas). Both verbs are forms of 'to choose' (eklegomai) as completed past actions in the middle voice (where the subject acts for its own benefit), and the negation of the human subject paired with the emphatic 'I' (ego) makes the divine choosing the prior and operative act, with the human relation following from it rather than originating it.

1John.4.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0025 ἀγαπῶμεν, G0025 ἠγάπησεν, G0846 αὐτός

Force. The clause 'we love' (hemeis agapomen) is grounded in 'because he first loved us' (hoti autos protos egapesen hemas). The adverb 'first' (protos) makes God's love explicitly prior in order to the human love, so the human response is presented as derivative of and consequent upon a divine act that precedes it.

Acts.16.14 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1272 διήνοιξεν, G2588 καρδίαν, G4337 προσέχειν, G2962 κύριος

Force. The narrative states that 'the Lord opened the heart' (ho kyrios dienoixen ten kardian) of Lydia, with the infinitive 'to attend' (prosechein, meaning to pay attention) expressing the result. The verb 'to open thoroughly' (dianoigo) occurs nine times in the Bible and consistently names a supernatural opening done to a recipient: opening eyes, Scriptures, minds and ears in Luke 24:31, 24:32, 24:45 and Mark 7:34. The divine opening precedes and produces the attending, so the human attention is consequent on the prior divine act.

Eph.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1435 δῶπον, G2316 θεοῦ, G1537 ἐξ, G1223 διὰ

Force. Salvation is by grace through faith, and the demonstrative 'this' (touto) is qualified as 'not from yourselves' (ouk ex hymon), but 'the gift of God' (theou doron). The framing sets the gift over against human origination, consistent with grace preceding the human response rather than assisting an autonomous first move.

Eph.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργων, G3756 οὐκ, G2744 καυχῆσθαι, G2443 ἵνα

Force. The phrase 'not from works' (ouk ex ergon) excludes works as the source, and the 'so that' clause (hina) states the purpose that no one may 'boast' (kauchesthai). Removing all ground of boasting in the human contribution reinforces that the initiative does not originate in the human will, though this verse addresses the source of salvation broadly rather than the will-grace ordering specifically.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.6.44	John.12.32	tsk	1
John.6.44	John.6.65	tsk	1
John.6.44	John.6.45	tsk	1
Acts.16.14	John.6.44	tsk	1
Acts.16.14	Rom.9.16	tsk	1
1John.4.19	John.15.16	tsk	1
Phil.2.13	2Chr.30.12	tsk	1
Rom.9.16	Rom.9.11	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.12.32 · addressed

The cross reference for John 6:44 uses the same verb 'to draw' (helkyo): 'and I, if I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all to myself' (kago ean hypsotho ek tes ges pantas helkyso pros emauton). Some read 'all' (pantas) as universalizing the drawing so that it no longer functions as a discriminating prior cause. That reading bears on the extent of the drawing, not on its priority. Lexically the verb 'to draw' (helkyo) still names a divine act that precedes coming, so the proposition about grace initiating the movement is sustained regardless of how the scope of 'all' (pantas) is resolved.

Rom.9.11 · addressed

The cross reference grounds Romans 9:16 in election 'not from works' (me ek ergon), before the twins had done anything good or bad. This strengthens rather than complicates the priority reading, since it removes prior human action as the basis. The lexical force of 'not of the one willing' (ou tou thelontos) in 9:16 is consistent with it.

Phil.2.12 · addressed

The immediately preceding verse commands 'work out' (katargazesthe) your own salvation, which on a cooperative reading keeps a real human acting alongside the divine working of 2:13. This does not complicate the priority claim, since the 'for' (gar) of 2:13 grounds the human working in God who first 'works' (energei) the willing. The human activity is presented as flowing from the prior divine operation, not as an unaided first step, so the ordering the proposition asserts holds while leaving the cooperation question open.

Concordance traversed

G1670, G1410, G1754, G2309, G1653, G1325, G1586, G1272, G1435, G2107, G2064, G3962, G2041, G2744

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

None of the cited verses fall within the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window of 3 John, so no apparatus units were examined here. The marked readings on the bundle surface forms, for example the bracketed 'me' in John 6:44 and the 'of the Father' (patros) note in John 6:65, touch the surrounding words but not the key terms 'is able' (dynatai), 'should draw' (helkyse), 'it has been given' (dedomenon), 'working' (energon), 'of the one willing' (thelontos), 'I chose' (exelexamen), 'first' (protos) or 'opened' (dienoixen) that carry the verdict, so the reading is treated as variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. monergism, synergism

analogia scripturae invoked

grace-initiates reading: affirms · Reads the priority markers as decisive against the semi-Pelagian (unaided human first step) claim. The negated 'is able' (dynatai) plus 'unless' (ean me) in John 6:44 and 6:65, 'not of the one willing' (ou tou thelontos) in Romans 9:16, 'working ... to will' (energon to thelein) in Philippians 2:13, the reversed 'to choose' (eklegomai) in John 15:16, the 'first' (protos) of 1 John 4:19 and the 'opened' (dienoixen) that produces 'to attend' (prosechein) in Acts 16:14 all locate the initiating act in God. On this lens the human cannot supply the first movement toward God by natural ability, because every cited construction places a divine act prior to and as the enabling ground of that movement.

synergistic cooperation reading: partially affirms · Grants the same priority that the texts assert, since 'to draw' (helkyo), 'to give' (didomi), 'to work in' (energeo), 'to choose' (eklegomai) and 'to open' (dianoigo) each name a real prior divine initiative, so this lens also denies the bare semi-Pelagian (unaided human first step) claim. It then distinguishes a narrower question the vocabulary does not settle, whether the prior grace fully effects the willing or enables a will that still freely and non-coercively consents. On this reading prevenient grace (grace that goes before) goes first and is necessary, yet a genuine human assent remains within the response, so the priority is affirmed while the completeness of the prior work is held open.

Both lenses agree that the cited key terms place a divine act before the human coming and therefore both reject the semi-Pelagian (unaided human first step) claim. They diverge only on the narrower and distinct question of whether that prior work fully effects the willing or enables a will that still consents. The shared lexical floor, which is what this proposition asserts, is that grace initiates the movement. The contested point lies beyond the proposition, in the completeness of that prior work, which the words do not rank.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the sinner can take the first step toward God by natural ability with grace then assisting, or whether a prior gracious work of God must enable any movement of the will toward Him.

VERDICT-CHANGED: the stem encodes its own conclusion in the clause 'rather, the prior gracious work of God enables any movement of the will toward Him', which loads the answer before the evidence is weighed. The verdict was derived on the neutralized form, which

poses the ordering as an open question. On the lexical merits the priority markers place the initiating act in God, which forecloses the specific semi-Pelagian (unaided human first step) claim. The narrower cooperation question, whether the prior work fully effects the willing, is not ranked by the vocabulary, which is reflected in medium confidence and the competing lens block.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.6.44
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Phil.2.13
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.15.16
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.16.14
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G1670
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G1272
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1754
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.6.44
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.16.14

License audit

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